SEMPLICE ITALIAN KITCHEN | QUICK ITALIAN DINNERS

Authentic Amalfi Pasta al Limone Without Cream (Silky 15-Minute Lemon Emulsion)

PREP: 5 mins | COOK: 10 mins | TOTAL: 15 mins | SERVINGS: 4 servings | CALORIES: 440 kcal

INGREDIENTS

* 400g (14 oz) Bronze-die Spaghetti or Linguine (cooked in a smaller pot of salted water to concentrate starch)
* 2 large Organic Unwaxed Lemons (zest of 2 lemons + 3 tbsp (45ml) fresh juice, divided)
* 45g (3 tbsp) Cold Unsalted Butter (cut into small 1/2-inch cubes)
* 2 tbsp (30ml) Extra-Virgin Olive Oil (plus extra for drizzling)
* 1 clove Fresh Garlic (lightly crushed whole (discarded after infusing))
* 85g (1 cup) Parmigiano-Reggiano DOP (finely grated on a microplane)
* 8 leaves Fresh Sweet Basil (hand-torn for garnish)
* to taste Fine Sea Salt & Freshly Cracked Black Pepper

STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Boil Pasta in Low-Volume Salted Water (8 mins)

Bring 2.5 quarts (2.4L) of water-about 30% less water than usual-to a boil with 1.5 tablespoons of sea salt. Add the spaghetti and cook for 2 minutes less than the package al dente time so the pasta finishes cooking directly in the pan emulsion.

Step 2: Infuse Garlic & Lemon Zest in Olive Oil (2 mins)

While the pasta boils, warm 2 tablespoons of extra-virgin olive oil and the whole crushed garlic clove in a wide stainless steel or enameled skillet over medium-low heat for 2 minutes until fragrant. Remove and discard the garlic clove, then turn off the heat and stir in three-quarters of the grated lemon zest so the warm oil unlocks its essential oils without browning.

Step 3: Build the Starchy Butter Emulsion (2 mins)

Ladle 3/4 cup (180ml) of starchy pasta cooking water into the skillet along with the cold cubed butter. Transfer the undercooked spaghetti directly into the skillet over medium-high heat. Toss and swirl vigorously with tongs for 2 minutes as the starch and butter fuse into a creamy, golden glaze.

Step 4: Emulsify Parmigiano & Lemon Juice Off Heat (2 mins)

Remove the skillet completely from the burner and wait 30 seconds. Pour in the 3 tablespoons of fresh lemon juice, then sprinkle in the finely microplaned Parmigiano-Reggiano in two stages while tossing rapidly and adding 1-2 splashes of pasta water as needed until every strand is cloaked in a glossy, velvety sauce.

Step 5: Garnish & Serve Immediately (1 mins)

Twirl into warmed bowls and top with the reserved fresh lemon zest, hand-torn basil leaves, freshly cracked black pepper, and a final thread of extra-virgin olive oil.

NONNA'S CHEF TIPS:

- Never add lemon juice while the skillet is over an active flame-waiting until the pan is off the heat keeps the Parmigiano silky and prevents graininess.
- Use a microplane rasp grater exclusively for the lemon zest so you only harvest the fragrant yellow skin and zero bitter white pith.